

Skins and Dolls

Sip

Chew

Drop

Sip

Chew

Drop

A repetition while staring across the table. A teacup in her hand, a biscuit in his.

Smiles plaster their faces, showing off full rows of teeth. Smile wide enough to reach their eyes, but not enough to wrinkle the edge.

How could they? Were dolls meant to be that happy?

They dressed up their little pastel dresses with the and rosy makeup. Their hair done so well it might as well be made from cardboard.

“Evangeline,” He would say.

“Brandon,” She would respond.

And so they repeat, the same smile, the *clink clink clink* of teacup on saucer and the crunch of his bite. Some days you could see his gums bleeding and some days you could see Evangeline’s turn green and lips charred and burnt.

Yet they continued to smile, they smiled with their full rows of teeth on display as she sips the almost empty cup and he repeats to bite on the biscuit.

“Why! I feel a bit tired, dear,” Evangeline set her teacup down, a remainder of black leaves at the bottom.

You couldn’t tell how they felt though, you can’t feel dolls, you only dress them up.

And so they were.

Giant hands grabbed Evangeline’s shoulder, yanking off her dress. The first layer and then the nest layer, her skin. It was like the sound of tape stuck to a cardboard box, ripping it out, unable for the box to stay intact. Her body pulsed, Brandon watched with the same smile on his face.

But so did Evangeline, she watched with her million-dollar-smile as his skin was zipping off of him.

When you’re a doll, you do not go to sleep.

Nabila Siddique

And you do not rest your head.

As a doll, you only smile as you take off the skin that you show the world. You take it off as comfort when the world isn't watching.

As much comfort a doll can get.

They stood there, hand in hand, tendons on tendons. Skinless feet leaving red marks on the floor.

Splotch, splotch, splotch.

It was like hitting Jello with a wooden spoon whenever they stirred a bit. The red of their muscles glowed like the smile they kept on.

The dolls will wait till dusk, they will be dressed up with a new pretty dress and pretty suit. A little teacup filled with green tea up the rim and biscuits restocked. Their position will change from standing to sitting again, with new skin and a new glow.

Another repeat of looking across each other and smiling, one yellowed and the other's gums bleeding.

Yet they will smile, just not enough to wrinkle the corner of their eyes, dolls can't have wrinkles.

Sip

Chew

Drop

Sip

Chew

Drop

"Evangeline," He will say.

"Brandon," She will respond.